

A weekly review of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear “so what for your school” line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, [get in touch](#).

TOP LINE

- Education secretary Lucy Powell told Schools Week she's planning changes to Ofsted's inspection framework 'within the next few months', responding to an NAHT survey of over 5,000 leaders in which nearly three-quarters said inspection has become more stressful since the renewed report-card framework began.
→ **For your school:** *Nothing to change yet, but worth flagging to senior leaders that an accountability shift may be coming before next term.*
- The education secretary unveiled a new whole-school plan to tackle misogyny on 26 September, backed by a £150,000 RSHE expert advisory group and two programmes launched under the £16m Violence Against Women and Girls Prevention Programme, aimed partly at countering the influence of figures like Andrew Tate.
→ **For your school:** *Ask your RSHE lead whether they've seen the new practical guides — they're designed to be used, not just filed.*
- Closing Labour's party conference in Liverpool, Powell confirmed new vocational GCSEs will replace existing technical awards from 2029 — but NFER immediately warned that, on international evidence, uneven take-up could widen rather than narrow socio-economic gaps.
→ **For your school:** *No immediate action, but a useful line to have ready if parents or governors ask whether this is a genuine alternative route or a rebrand.*
- The DfE has shared draft 'reasonable adjustments' guidance for SEND pupils in mainstream schools with trust leaders, giving worked examples such as a supervised early-arrival window for a pupil whose sensory processing needs affect attendance.
→ **For your school:** *Worth getting in front of your SENDCo now, since these examples will likely shape what Ofsted treats as 'reasonable' once finalised.*

DATES FOR THE DIARY

- 7 Oct 2026** — Rotherham's Overview and Scrutiny Management Board considers a review of school-gate parking safety and CCTV enforcement.
- 8 Oct 2026** — 2026-27 pupil premium quarter 2 allocations due to be paid to academies.
- 11 Nov 2026** — 5pm deadline for Care to Learn and 16-19 Bursary Fund (defined vulnerable groups element) funding claim forms.
- 2 Nov 2026** — Extended deadline for completing FSM autumn-census eligibility checks (carried over from last issue).

NATIONAL POLICY

- **Powell unveils vocational GCSEs at Labour conference.** Closing Labour's conference in Liverpool (27-30 September), education secretary Lucy Powell confirmed plans for new vocational GCSEs — covering subjects such as business management, child development and construction — to replace existing technical awards from 2029, sitting alongside A-levels, T-levels and the new V-levels in a reshaped 16-19

progression landscape. Powell framed it as ending 'the snobbery towards technical education', a message aimed as much at her own party as at schools. ([Schools Week \(Labour conference live blog\)](#))

→ **For your school:** *Nothing to action given the 2029 start date, but worth flagging to careers leads and Year 9 options teams as an early planning signal.*

■ **NFER warns the new GCSEs could widen inequality if take-up is patchy.** Responding within days of the conference announcement, NFER's Jude Hillary cautioned that international evidence shows earlier academic/vocational tracking tends to entrench rather than narrow socio-economic gaps, since subject choices at 14 often reflect prior attainment and family background as much as aptitude. The government insists it isn't formally splitting pupils into two tracks — but NFER's point is that uneven take-up could do exactly that in practice. ([Schools Week](#))

→ **For your school:** *A useful line to have ready if parents or governors ask whether the new qualifications are a genuine alternative route or a lower-status one by another name.*

■ FUNDING

■ **Autumn school census opened Thursday 1 October.** This year's return — which feeds directly into funding allocations including the National Funding Formula and growth funding calculations — opened on 1 October, after the DfE's final familiarisation window for checking data closed on 25 September. Local authority return deadlines vary, so don't assume the DfE's own later cut-off applies to your school. ([GOV.UK \(DfE Update academies, 30 September 2026\)](#))

→ **For your school:** *If this hasn't already gone through your usual data-checking process, chase whoever holds it today — errors here flow straight into next year's budget.*

■ **Two further funding deadlines from this week's DfE Update.** The same 30 September update confirmed the quarter 2 update to 2026-27 pupil premium allocations, with payment due to academies on Thursday 8 October, and opened funding claim forms for the Care to Learn and 16-19 Bursary Fund's defined vulnerable groups element, due by 5pm on Wednesday 11 November. ([GOV.UK \(DfE Update academies, 30 September 2026\)](#))

→ **For your school:** *Both dates are now in the diary below — diarise them locally too if either funding stream applies to your setting.*

■ INCLUSION & SEND

■ **DfE tests draft guidance on 'reasonable' SEND adjustments for mainstream schools.** As part of the wider SEND reform package, the DfE has shared draft examples with trust leaders of what counts as a reasonable — and unreasonable — adjustment for pupils with additional needs: for instance, a supervised early-arrival window and access to a low-stimulation space for a pupil whose sensory processing needs affect attendance. It's a practical companion to the Code of Practice revision promised in the schools white paper, and lands the same week Ofsted's own inclusion grading area (see below) continues to bed in, so expect the two to be read together by inspectors and schools alike. ([Tes](#))

→ **For your school:** *Worth getting in front of your SENDCo now — these examples will likely shape what Ofsted treats as 'reasonable' once finalised.*

■ BEHAVIOUR, EXCLUSIONS & ATTENDANCE

■ **A quiet week for English data — but Wales offers a stark illustration.** Neath Port Talbot council fined 159 parents and took 48 to court over school absence in 2025/26, while 638 pupils were excluded — persistent disruptive behaviour the leading cause, and the exclusion rate among girls now nearly double its 2018/19 level. No comparable English national dataset landed this week, but the gendered shift mirrors a pattern researchers have also flagged in English figures. ([Swansea Bay News](#))

→ **For your school:** *If your own behaviour data shows a similar drift in who's being excluded, it's worth raising internally before it surfaces in an inspection.*

■ OFSTED & ACCOUNTABILITY

■ **Powell signals Ofsted changes 'within the next few months'.** Following NAHT's survey of over 5,000 leaders — nearly three-quarters of whom said inspection had got more stressful under the renewed

framework, with the union demanding a pause on graded inspections over fears for leaders' health — Powell told Schools Week she's planning changes to make the accountability system 'more supportive and understanding'. NAHT's general secretary called a timeframe of 'months rather than weeks' a 'problem', so expect continued pressure before anything concrete lands. ([Schools Week](#))

→ **For your school:** *Not actionable yet, but worth watching — any framework change would affect how you prepare for inspection from next term.*

■ SAFEGUARDING & WELLBEING

■ **Education secretary unveils whole-school plan to tackle misogyny.** Announced 26 September, the plan gives schools practical guides, teacher training and parent-support resources to counter the influence of figures like Andrew Tate, backed by a new £150,000 RSHE expert advisory group and two programmes launched under the £16m Violence Against Women and Girls Prevention Programme. It follows Ofsted's own observation of a 'growing scourge' of classroom misogyny, linking this week's safeguarding announcement to the accountability conversation above. ([GOV.UK](#))

→ **For your school:** *Check whether your RSHE lead has seen the new guides yet — they're designed to be used rather than filed.*

■ SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

■ **Rotherham reviews school-gate parking safety after dangerous-driving complaints.** A scrutiny review — going to Rotherham's Overview and Scrutiny Management Board on 7 October — found just one council CCTV enforcement van currently covers more than 200 school access points, with parents reporting dangerous parking, blocked driveways and near-misses at drop-off and pick-up. Councillor Adam Tinsley, who chaired the review, is pushing for stronger enforcement action. ([Rotherham Advertiser](#))

→ **For your school:** *If this resonates, it's worth checking whether your own travel plan addresses drop-off congestion before a similar review lands locally.*

■ **Five of Rotherham's 16 secondaries are oversubscribed on first choice.** New analysis of government data shows five of Rotherham's 16 secondary schools received more first-choice applications than places available, with St Bernard's Catholic High School the most oversubscribed — 254 first-choice applications for 146 places. It's a reminder that place pressure isn't only a Sheffield city story; it sits alongside this week's autumn census (above) as another data point local authorities will be watching closely this term. ([Rotherham Advertiser](#))

→ **For your school:** *Useful context if parents raise oversubscription concerns with you ahead of secondary application season.*

JARGON-BUSTER – V-LEVEL

Comes up in this week's vocational GCSEs story (National policy, above).

A new post-16 qualification sitting alongside A-levels and T-levels, aimed at 16-19 learners wanting a mix of classroom and applied vocational study. The new vocational GCSEs announced this week are pitched as the 14-16 on-ramp into this three-track system — so what you teach pre-16 will increasingly map onto one of the three routes.

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. [Explore School+](#)

■ SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		

Source	Type	What we track
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Weekly is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.